

Naxalites who describe the state as the 'enemy' and the conflict as a 'war'. If this is a war—it has been thrust upon the state," Chidambaram said a day after the massacre.

The Maoists who control 83 districts of the 220 in which they operate stepped up their war against the state last year. It was their response to Operation Green Hunt, the first centrally coordinated offensive, which began in November 2009. The surge saw over 60,000 personnel being pushed into the worst-affected states along with grants for modernisation of forces and development package.

Last year was the bloodiest year in the fight against the Maoists—591 civilians and 317 security forces were killed by Maoists. Naxal attacks were carried out with unprecedented ferocity. Police personnel were beheaded and trains hijacked.

Yet, the Dantewada toll, which exceeded the CRPF's death toll in 2009, has left the government floundering. For the past five years, the Government's anti-Naxal strategy rested on three planks: pushing in Central forces, giving states money for police modernisation and developing Maoist-affected areas. Until last year, this strategy, existed mainly on paper.

The Maoists meanwhile thrived on a well-oiled economy of extortion, kidnapping and theft. Training was refined—Home Ministry officials believe former military personnel could be training Maoists—and PLGA CADRES mobilised and armed themselves with weapons looted from state forces.

An elaborate network of over-ground workers and an effective propaganda machine and moist-eyed activists created a myth of exploited people fighting for their legitimate rights. The Maoists, they would have you believe, represent an Indian parallel to the gentle, indigenous Na'vi fighting the rapacious interplanetary corporation in James Cameron's *Avatar*. Clearly this is a war that has

Graphic by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY/www.indiatodayimages.com

THE KEY FAILURES

The Dantewada debacle was compounded by failures at all levels leading to a near-total wipeout of 'A' company of the CRPF's 82nd Battalion.



An 81-member company of the CRPF was ambushed by Maoists while returning from a two-day patrol on April 6. A Mine Protected Vehicle and a mobile bunker were destroyed and 76 personnel killed by gunfire and IEDs.

1 STRATEGY

Reclaim and hold operations were too sparse and not backed by development programmes. Few CRPF personnel to tackle Maoists.

2 INTELLIGENCE

Little ground intelligence. The company was unaware of being surrounded. It camped in a village and entered and left from the same route.

3 LEADERSHIP

No recce, taking too large a group and exposing troops. A good commander would have rallied men and returned fire.

4 TACTICS

Cardinal rule of counter-insurgency, to stay away from the roads and adopt different entry and exits, not followed.

5 COMMUNICATION

Counter-ambush drills were not followed. The second company which was nearby unable to come to the rescue of the besieged 'A' company.

6 EQUIPMENT

Did not have adequate indirect fire weapons like mortars which can lay heavy fire on ambushing forces.

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